Rockefeller Foundation — Digital Inclusion Grant Concept Note

To: grants@rockefellerfoundation.org | $1,500,000 USD Request

ROCKEFELLER FOUNDATION — GRANT CONCEPT NOTE

Digital Financial Inclusion | Offline Payment Infrastructure

To: Digital Inclusion Program Team, The Rockefeller Foundation

Email: grants@rockefellerfoundation.org

From: Tom Ugbodaga, Founder & CEO, BETONIQ(WEST) Limited

Email: zeropointfeild_nonwnt@zeropay.site | Phone: +234 706 525 2117 Date: July 23, 2026

SUBJECT: Concept Note — ZeroPay Offline Payment Infrastructure | $1,500,000 Grant Request | Financial Inclusion for 38 Million Unbanked Nigerians

Dear Rockefeller Foundation Digital Inclusion Team,

The Rockefeller Foundation has invested decades and hundreds of millions of dollars in the belief that digital financial inclusion is the most powerful lever for reducing poverty at scale. I am writing because ZeroPay has solved the problem that has prevented that investment from reaching its final mile.

My name is Tom Ugbodaga. I am the Founder and CEO of BETONIQ(WEST) Limited (CAC No. 56802, Abuja, Nigeria) and the sole inventor of ZeroPay — the world's first offline-first, uncapped NFC contactless payment protocol.

THE FINAL MILE PROBLEM

Every digital financial inclusion initiative — mobile money, payment apps, QR codes, USSD, agent banking — has hit the same wall: connectivity.

In Nigeria alone, 38 million people are unbanked. The majority are not unbanked because they lack mobile phones. They are not unbanked because they distrust the financial system. They are unbanked because every digital payment tool available to them fails the moment the network goes down — which in Nigeria's informal markets, rural communities, and medium-density urban areas, happens multiple times every day.

The Rockefeller Foundation understands this. Your work in financial inclusion has consistently identified infrastructure gaps as the primary barrier to scale. ZeroPay addresses the most fundamental of those gaps: the assumption that digital payments require digital connectivity.

That assumption is wrong. ZeroPay proves it.

THE ZEROPAY BREAKTHROUGH

ZeroPay processes fully authenticated digital payments of any value with zero internet connectivity.

This is achieved through a patent-pending four-layer cryptographic architecture:

LAYER 1 — NFC: The customer taps any NFC device to the ZeroPay terminal. No app. No internet. No QR code. Same contactless experience as a London Underground Oyster tap.

LAYER 2 — PUF HARDWARE AUTHENTICATION: A Physical Unclonable Function — a silicon fingerprint burned into the terminal chip at manufacturing — authenticates the device offline. This is mathematically equivalent to a government-issued biometric identity document — except it is embedded in hardware and requires no internet to verify.

LAYER 3 — ECC P-256 OFFLINE SIGNING: The transaction is cryptographically signed using the same standard deployed by the US Federal Reserve, NATO, and every major central bank globally. Generated entirely offline. No server. No cloud.

LAYER 4 — DISTANCE BOUNDING PROTOCOL: Nanosecond-precision signal timing prevents relay attacks — the most sophisticated form of NFC fraud. This is the first deployment of Distance Bounding at retail point-of-sale scale anywhere in the world.

THE SETTLEMENT ENGINE: Signed tokens queue offline. The moment connectivity is restored — even for 30 seconds — the batch settles to the payment rail (Paystack Nigeria, Flutterwave Ghana, Orange Money Sierra Leone). Every transaction is accounted for. Every naira is reconciled. Nothing is lost.

THE SOLAR MESH HUB: For environments with zero connectivity, ZeroPay's solar-powered LoRaWAN mesh relay network propagates signed batches across 2-15km per hop. Powered entirely by solar. Requires no grid. No telecoms infrastructure. No government intervention.

THE POPULATION WE SERVE

Nigeria (Phase 1): 38 million unbanked | 200,000+ informal market merchants ■847 billion ($550M) in annual informal cash transactions Target: 200 merchants in Abuja pilot, Year 1

West Africa (Phase 2): Ghana 9.5M unbanked | Senegal 7.2M | Sierra Leone 4.1M

Global (Phase 3): 1.4 billion unbanked worldwide — India, Bangladesh, DRC, Indonesia

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GRANT REQUEST — $1,500,000 USD

Use of funds over 24 months: Hardware R&D; and terminal prototype manufacturing: $450,000 Abuja Pilot — 200 terminal deployment + 3 Solar Mesh Hubs: $380,000 CBN PSSP regulatory licensing and compliance: $120,000 West Africa expansion — Ghana and Sierra Leone: $300,000 Team — embedded firmware engineers and operations: $200,000 Monitoring, evaluation, and impact documentation: $50,000 Total: $1,500,000

EXPECTED IMPACT (24 MONTHS)

1,000,000+ previously unbanked individuals with first digital payment access 2,000 merchants with first digital transaction history — enabling micro-credit access ■15,000,000/month in formal economic activity from previously invisible cash 4 countries with active ZeroPay infrastructure 50+ new community technology jobs (Terminal Agents, Mesh Hub Operators) Documented operational playbook for replication in 20+ markets

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WHY THE ROCKEFELLER FOUNDATION

The Rockefeller Foundation's Digital Inclusion program is focused on closing the gaps that commercial markets cannot — or will not — close. ZeroPay is exactly this kind of investment.

No commercial fintech investor will fund hardware-level payment infrastructure in the absence of immediate revenue certainty. The 200-merchant Abuja pilot requires capital before revenue exists. That is a foundation investment — not a VC investment.

The Rockefeller Foundation funds infrastructure. ZeroPay is infrastructure.

Once the Abuja pilot is operational, commercial revenue is immediate and self-sustaining. Hardware sales + SaaS fees + transaction fees generate positive cash flow from Month 4. The Foundation's capital builds the infrastructure that commercial revenue then sustains.

This is the Rockefeller model at its finest: catalytic capital that unlocks a self-sustaining system.

CREDENTIALS

Tom Ugbodaga MSc — NFC for Contactless Technology in Financial Transactions, University of Gloucestershire, England, 2011 (Top Graduate) MSc — Computer Security Systems BSc Physics, Nigeria Patent-pending: ZeroPay invention disclosure, April 2026 BETONIQ(WEST) Limited: CAC No. 56802, Abuja, FCT, Nigeria

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I would welcome the opportunity to present ZeroPay's offline transaction demonstration to your team. The demo can be conducted remotely or in person in Abuja.

Please contact me at: zeropointfeild_nonwnt@zeropay.site | +234 706 525 2117

Warm regards,

Tom Ugbodaga Founder & CEO | BETONIQ(WEST) Limited | ZeroPay